

Wheezing

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Reviewed/Revised Nov 2025

Wheezing is a high-pitched, whistling sound that occurs during breathing when the airways are partially blocked. (See also [Wheezing in Infants and Young Children](#).)

AUDIO

Causes of Wheezing

[Wheezing](#)



Wheezing results from a narrowing or partial blockage (obstruction) somewhere in the airways. The narrowing may be widespread (as occurs in asthma, chronic obstructive pulmonary disease [COPD], and some severe allergic reactions) or only in one area (as may result from a tumor or a foreign object lodged in an airway).

Common causes

Overall, the most common causes are:

- [Asthma](#)
- [COPD](#)

Less common causes

Wheezing may occur in other disorders that affect the small airways, including [heart failure](#), a severe allergic reaction ([anaphylaxis](#)), and [inhalation of a toxic substance](#).

Wheezing caused by heart failure is called cardiac asthma. Medications such as angiotensin-converting enzyme (ACE) inhibitors, beta-blockers, aspirin, and other nonsteroidal anti-inflammatory drugs (NSAIDs) can cause wheezing.

Sometimes, otherwise healthy people wheeze during a bout of [acute bronchitis](#). In children, wheezing may be caused by [bronchiolitis](#) (infection of the lower respiratory tract) or inhalation (aspiration) of a foreign object (see table

[Some Causes and Features of Wheezing](#)).

Evaluation of Wheezing

A person with severe breathing problems (respiratory distress) is evaluated and treated at the same time.

The following information can help people decide when a doctor's evaluation is needed and help them know what to expect during the evaluation.

Warning signs

In people with wheezing, the following symptoms are of particular concern:

- Labored breathing, weakening efforts to breathe, or a decreased level of consciousness
- Swelling of the face and tongue

When to see a doctor

People with warning signs or shortness of breath should go to the hospital emergency department immediately, by ambulance if necessary. People who have wheezing that comes and goes and are not short of breath should call their doctor as soon as possible.

What the doctor does

Doctors first ask questions about the person's symptoms and medical history and then do a physical examination. What doctors find during the history and physical examination often suggests a cause and the tests that may need to be done (see table [Some Causes and Features of Wheezing](#)).

Doctors determine whether the wheezing is occurring for the first time or has occurred before. If the person has had wheezing before, they determine whether current symptoms are different in nature or severity.

Important clues to a diagnosis are:

- Whether the wheezing started suddenly or gradually
- Whether it comes and goes
- Whether any conditions (such as an upper respiratory infection, exposure to an allergen, particular seasons of the year, cold air, exercise, or feeding in infants) trigger it or make it worse

Other symptoms that can provide clues to the diagnosis include [shortness of breath](#), fever, [cough](#), and sputum production. Doctors ask about the person's history of smoking and exposure to secondhand smoke and history of asthma or COPD.

During the physical examination, doctors check the person's temperature and heart and breathing rates. Doctors look for signs of respiratory distress and examine the lungs, particularly how well air moves in and out and whether wheezing seems to affect both lungs or a specific area of the lungs. A doctor is usually able to detect wheezing by listening with a stethoscope as the person breathes. Loud wheezing can be heard easily, sometimes even without a stethoscope. To hear mild wheezing, doctors may need to listen with a stethoscope while the person exhales forcefully. A persistent wheeze that occurs in one location in people who smoke may be due to lung cancer. Doctors also examine the heart for murmurs and abnormal sounds, nose and throat for airway obstruction, legs and feet for swelling, nails for clubbing, and skin for cyanosis or rash.



Some Causes and Features of Wheezing

Cause	Common Features*	Tests†
<u>Acute bronchitis</u>	Cough Sometimes symptoms of an upper respiratory infection (such as a stuffy nose) Usually no known history of a lung disorder	A doctor's examination
<u>Allergic reactions</u>	Wheezing that starts suddenly, usually within 30 minutes of exposure to a known or potential allergen such as pollen Often a stuffy nose, hives, itchy eyes, and sneezing	A doctor's examination Allergy testing Blood test to measure the level of eosinophils (a type of white blood cell involved in allergic reactions)
<u>Asthma</u>	Usually a history of asthma Wheezing that starts spontaneously or after exposure to specific stimuli (such as pollen or another allergen, an upper respiratory infection, cold, or exercise)	A doctor's examination Sometimes one or more of the following tests: • Tests to evaluate how well the lungs are functioning (<u>pulmonary function tests</u>) • Measurement of peak air flow (how fast air can be exhaled) • Measurement of lung function



MSD

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